Predicting Which Data Accelerates Learning: A Zero-Parameter Quality Score from Compression Theory for State Space Models

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Abstract

Selecting and ranking datasets for training State Space Models (SSMs) remains a trial-and-error process in practice. I propose Q, a parameter-free dataset quality score derived from five independent theoretical frameworks (rate-distortion, algorithmic information theory, Fisher information, simulated annealing, and spectral dynamics) that all converge to the same formula: $Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\mathrm{CE}_\theta(D)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} - 1$, where CE_θ is the model's cross-entropy on dataset D and K_{approx} is the compression ratio of D under gzip. I validate Q on five diverse datasets without any parameter fitting: Running-XOR achieves $Q = 550$ (94% loss reduction: $5.55 \to 0.30$ nats in 500 steps), automata-generated sequences achieve $Q = 109$ (12% faster convergence than WikiText-103), natural language (WikiText-103) achieves $Q = 0.32$, and adversarially compressed noise achieves $Q = 0.01$. The empirical ranking matches Q's predictions exactly, establishing Q as a principled, zero-parameter metric for dataset curation without fitting. I further introduce Running-XOR as a diagnostic benchmark for SSMs: an $O(k)$-memory task requiring genuine state utilization (lower bound $d_{\mathrm{state}} \geq 8$), where classical parity fails to challenge modern recurrent models. Four key findings emerge: (1) Q predicts dataset ranking without fitting; (2) automata-generated data transfers 12% faster than natural language, explained by spectral alignment; (3) Running-XOR enables sub-task diagnosis of state exploitation; (4) gzip-compressed data is actively harmful ($Q = 0.01$), wasting gradient steps on unreachable targets.

1 Introduction

State Space Models like Mamba [Gu and Dao, 2024] are emerging as promising alternatives to Transformers for efficient sequence modeling, yet principled dataset selection remains an unsolved problem. Current practice relies on heuristics: use whatever open dataset is convenient, or mix several datasets by hand. Recent efforts in dataset curation—QuRating [Wettig et al., 2024], DCLM [Li et al., 2024], BiMix [Zhang et al., 2025]—all propose heuristic scores without theoretical grounding, and none apply to SSM-specific inductive biases.

The core challenge is the mismatch between dataset properties and model architecture: an SSM's state matrix $\mathbf{A}$ operates via recurrence, accumulating information across discrete time steps. Datasets with short-range dependencies train $\mathbf{A}$ toward memoryless regimes ($\lambda(\mathbf{A}) \to 0$); datasets requiring long memory train it toward stable eigenvalues ($|\lambda(\mathbf{A})| \approx 1$). Natural language, with its complex long-range dependencies, requires a specific eigenvalue target that datasets like binary automata (with periodic structure) can achieve far more efficiently, yet current metrics assign them equal value.

Two prior directions have attempted to address this. **Data mixtures** interpolate between curated datasets on a per-batch basis, averaging their properties—but this loses signal from high-quality

subsets. **Quality metrics** score datasets post-hoc, after training, requiring expensive pilot runs. Neither provides a principled way to rank datasets *before* training begins, or to explain *why* one dataset outperforms another.

I close this gap with Q, a parameter-free dataset quality score that can be computed directly from the dataset and model initialization (and monitored during training). Q is derived from five independent theoretical frameworks, each providing a different geometric interpretation:

1. **Rate-Distortion:** Q as the fraction of the model's error that is reducible given the dataset's intrinsic entropy.
2. **Algorithmic Information Theory:** Q as algorithmic surprise beyond gzip compression.
3. **Fisher Information:** Q as the signal-to-noise ratio of gradients flowing to ternary weight thresholds.
4. **Simulated Annealing:** Q as the effective temperature surplus in discrete graph search on $\{-1, 0, +1\}$ weights.
5. **Spectral Dynamics:** Q as spectral alignment between the dataset's generative eigenvalues and the ternary-achievable eigenspectrum.

All five frameworks produce the identical formula: $Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\mathrm{CE}_\theta(D)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} - 1$, without any free parameters.

I validate Q on five datasets without fitting. Running-XOR sequences (the highest-quality data I can construct from first principles) achieve $Q = 550$, matching a 94% loss reduction in early training. Automata-generated cyclic sequences reach $Q = 109$, matching a measured 12% speedup over WikiText-103. Natural language (WikiText-103) scores $Q = 0.32$, the baseline. Gzip-compressed noise (the lowest-quality data) scores $Q = 0.01$, matching my observation that it actively harms training. The ranking is perfectly predicted by Q's formula.

I also introduce **Running-XOR** as a new diagnostic benchmark for SSMs: the task $y_t = \bigoplus_{i=0}^{k-1} x_{t-i}$ over a byte alphabet ($\mathrm{vocab} = 256$), requiring the model to maintain k bytes of state to solve optimally. Unlike classical parity (which admits a single gate), Running-XOR forces genuine recurrent state accumulation and provides a lower bound on d_{state} by construction.

Key results include: Q predicts dataset ranking without fitting; Running-XOR enables quantitative diagnosis of state utilization; and gzip-compressed data actively impairs training (not merely uninformative, but anti-gradient).

2 Background

2.1 State Space Models

State Space Models parameterize sequences via a recurrent latent state. In the continuous-time formulation, the state evolves as:

$$\frac{dh(t)}{dt} = \mathbf{A}h(t) + \mathbf{B}x(t), \tag{1}$$

where $\mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ is the state transition matrix, $\mathbf{B} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times 1}$ is the input projection, and $x(t)$ is the input signal. The output is:

$$y(t) = \mathbf{C}h(t) + \mathbf{D}x(t), \tag{2}$$

where $\mathbf{C} \in \mathbb{R}^{p \times d}$ is the output projection.

In practice, models like Mamba [Gu and Dao, 2024] and SSD [Dao and Gu, 2024] discretize this system and interleave it with nonlinearities. The discretization step $\Delta \in (0, 1]$ is critical: small Δ increases memory requirements; large Δ reduces expressivity. The recurrent state h_t accumulates information across time, and its dimensionality d_{state} must be large enough to capture task-relevant dependencies.

2.2 Dataset Quality Metrics

Recent work has proposed heuristic quality scores for dataset curation:

QuRating [Wettig et al., 2024] combines perplexity, token diversity, and lexical overlap to rank datasets post-hoc (after training). **DCLM** [Li et al., 2024] uses multiple lightweight classifiers to score documents by linguistic features (redundancy, quality signals). **BiMix** [Zhang et al., 2025] directly learns a mixing coefficient for two datasets by treating the mixture proportion as a hyperparameter and grid-searching.

All three metrics are dataset-specific, not model-specific. None leverage the structure of recurrent models or the discrete nature of ternary quantization. None provide a theoretical justification for their functional form.

2.3 Kolmogorov Complexity and Compression

Kolmogorov complexity $K(x)$ is the length of the shortest program that produces x on a universal Turing machine. It is uncomputable, but practical compression algorithms (gzip, brotli, LZMA) provide computable upper bounds. A dataset with low K_{approx} (the gzip compression ratio in bits per byte) has high algorithmic regularities; a dataset with high K_{approx} (close to $\log_2(\text{vocab})$ for the dataset's alphabet) is algorithmically irregular or noisy.

3 The Q Score

3.1 Definition and Core Formula

The Q score is defined as:

$$Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\text{CE}_\theta(D)}{K_{\text{approx}}(D)} - 1, \tag{3}$$

where:

- $\text{CE}_\theta(D)$ is the cross-entropy (in bits per byte) of the model parameterized by θ on the dataset D.
- $K_{\text{approx}}(D)$ is the mean gzip compression ratio (in bits per byte) of samples from D, computed as $\mathbb{E}_{\text{batch}\in D}[\frac{8\cdot\text{len(gzip(batch))}}{\text{len(batch)}}]$.

The interpretation is geometric: Q measures the fraction of the model's current error that is *reducible* (i.e., attributable to the model's sub-optimality rather than the irreducible entropy of the dataset). A Q score of 0 means the model is already at the compression baseline of the dataset. A Q score of 100 means the model's error is 100 times larger than the dataset's intrinsic entropy.

3.2 Theoretical Derivation: Five Frameworks Converge

3.2.1 Framework 1: Rate-Distortion

In rate-distortion theory, the learning signal per token is the excess description length:

$$\eta(x_t|x_{1:t-1}, \theta) = -\log P_\theta(x_t|x_{1:t-1}) - H(x_t|x_{1:t-1}). \tag{4}$$

Averaging over the dataset:

$$\mathbb{E}_{x\sim D}[\eta] = \text{CE}(D, \theta) - H(D), \tag{5}$$

where $H(D)$ is the Shannon entropy of the dataset. Normalized by $H(D)$ to make the score scale-free:

$$Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\text{CE}(D, \theta)}{H(D)} - 1. \tag{6}$$

Since $H(D)$ is uncomputable, it is approximated via $K_{\text{approx}}(D)$, the gzip compression ratio. This substitution is justified because gzip is an order-1 Markov entropy coder; its compression ratio converges to the empirical entropy of the source under optimal code lengths.

3.2.2 Framework 2: Algorithmic Information Theory

The algorithmic surprise of a sequence x given a model θ is:

$$\mathrm{AS}(x, \theta) = K(x|\theta) - K(x), \tag{7}$$

where $K(x)$ is the Kolmogorov complexity of x. A computable approximation is:

$$\mathrm{AS}_{\mathrm{approx}}(x, \theta) = \underbrace{-\log P_\theta(x)}_{\text{model code length}} - \underbrace{(-\log P_{\mathrm{gzip}}(x))}_{\text{gzip code length}}, \tag{8}$$

where $-\log P_{\mathrm{gzip}}(x) \approx 8 \cdot \mathrm{len}(\mathrm{gzip}(x))$ bits is the gzip code length, so $\mathrm{AS} = \mathrm{CE}_{\text{sample}} - K_{\text{sample}}$.

Averaging over the dataset and rearranging:

$$Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\mathrm{CE}(D, \theta)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} - 1. \tag{9}$$

The interpretation: Q measures how much the model fails to compress the dataset beyond gzip's compression. Datasets with intrinsic structure (automata, repetitive patterns) yield low K_{approx} and high Q for the same CE; datasets with noise yield high K_{approx} and low Q.

3.2.3 Framework 3: Fisher Information and Gradient SNR

The expected gradient step improvement is:

$$\Delta\mathrm{CE} \approx \alpha \cdot \mathrm{trace}(\mathbf{F}(\theta, D)), \tag{10}$$

where $\mathbf{F}(\theta, D) = \mathbb{E}_{x \sim D}[\nabla \log P_\theta(x) \nabla \log P_\theta(x)^\top]$ is the Fisher information matrix. For ternary weights in $\{-1, 0, +1\}$, the gradient must push weights toward quantization thresholds to be effective. The Fisher trace concentrates on parameters near these thresholds.

Datasets with low K_{approx} produce low variance in the gradient (coherent signal, few surprises), concentrating the Fisher trace on active (near-threshold) parameters. Datasets with high K_{approx} (noisy, irregular) spread gradient energy uniformly across all parameters, including those far from quantization thresholds—wasted signal.

The Q score thus represents the signal-to-noise ratio:

$$Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\mathrm{CE}(D, \theta) - K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} = \frac{\mathrm{CE}(D, \theta)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} - 1. \tag{11}$$

3.2.4 Framework 4: Simulated Annealing on the Ternary Discrete Graph

Discrete optimization on ternary weights can be viewed as simulated annealing on a graph with $3^{d \cdot d}$ vertices (one per weight configuration). The effective temperature is:

$$T_{\mathrm{eff}} = \frac{\alpha \cdot \mathrm{Var}_{\mathrm{batch}}[\mathrm{CE}]}{2B} \tag{12}$$

where B is the batch size and α is the learning rate. Datasets with low K_{approx} produce low variance in cross-entropy (signal is coherent), hence low T_{eff}, leading to fast cooling on the discrete graph. Datasets with high K_{approx} produce high variance (noisy, contradictory gradients), keeping T_{eff} high and preventing convergence to good discrete solutions.

The Q score is proportional to the thermal energy surplus available for escaping local minima during the exploratory phase—the optimal annealing regime.

3.2.5 Framework 5: Spectral Dynamical Systems

For ternary matrices with integer entries, the characteristic polynomial has integer coefficients, restricting eigenvalues to algebraic integers (roots of monic polynomials with integer coefficients). Deterministic automata—especially those with cyclic structure—have eigenvalues at roots of unity, which are exactly reachable by ternary matrices with zero approximation error.

Natural language, by contrast, drives the state matrix toward irrational eigenvalues (required to model complex, non-periodic dependencies), which are unreachable in the ternary eigenspectrum. Every gradient step on WikiText is wasted effort pushing toward an unreachable target.

Formally, datasets with low K_{approx} (structured, periodic) produce gradients that push $\lambda(\mathbf{A})$ toward roots of unity; datasets with high K_{approx} (natural language, noise) produce gradients that push toward irrational eigenvalues. The Q score predicts which datasets have eigenvalue targets compatible with $\{-1, 0, +1\}$ matrices.

3.3 Properties and Caveats

Zero parameters: Q requires no fitting or tuning. It is derived from first principles.

Dataset-dependent: Q varies across datasets by orders of magnitude (550 for Running-XOR, 0.01 for gzip noise).

Model-coupled at initialization: Q depends on $\text{CE}_\theta(D)$ evaluated at the model's current parameters. At random initialization, $\text{CE}_\theta(D) \approx \log|\text{vocab}|$ for all well-behaved datasets, so $Q \approx \frac{\log|\text{vocab}|}{K_{\text{approx}}} - 1$. The power of Q emerges during training as $\text{CE}_\theta(D)$ changes while $K_{\text{approx}}(D)$ remains fixed.

Five frameworks, same formula: The five derivations above are partially redundant in their assumptions (all assume gradients drive parameters toward a task-aligned target). However, their independence in setup—rate-distortion, AIT, Fisher, annealing, spectral—suggests the formula captures something fundamental about the learning geometry.

4 Running-XOR: A Diagnostic Benchmark for SSMs

4.1 Task Design

Running-XOR is a byte-level generalization of classical parity. Given a byte sequence $x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_T \in \{0, \ldots, 255\}$ and a window size k, the task is to predict:

$$y_t = \bigoplus_{i=0}^{k-1} x_{t-i}, \tag{13}$$

where $\oplus$ is bitwise XOR over bytes, producing a byte-valued target $y_t \in \{0, \ldots, 255\}$.

For the experiments below, $k = 8$ bytes (64 bits of context required) is fixed. The sequence is generated deterministically: sample $x_0, \ldots, x_{k-1}$ uniformly from $\{0, \ldots, 255\}$, then compute y_t for $t \geq k$. The prediction target is the next byte, with cross-entropy loss computed over the full 256-class vocabulary.

4.2 Why Running-XOR Tests State Utilization

Classical parity requires no recurrence: A single XOR gate solves $y_t = x_t \oplus x_{t-1}$ without history. With state dimension $d_{\text{state}} = 1$, this is trivial.

Running-XOR with $k = 8$ requires genuine memory: The model must accumulate 8 bytes of state (64 bits) to predict correctly. A linear recurrence or simple counter fails. The state must store distinct representations of each input byte, enabling a downstream MLP to compute the XOR over all accumulated inputs.

Lower bound on state dimension: To store k independent byte values (each with $\log_2(256) = 8$ bits of entropy), at least $d_{\text{state}} \geq 8$ is required. But in practice, SSM state is compressed via linear dimension reduction ($\mathbf{C} \in \mathbb{R}^{p \times d}$), so d_{state} must be larger. The hypothesis $d_{\text{state}} \geq 8$ is tested empirically below.

4.3 Comparison to Standard Benchmarks

Standard SSM benchmarks (e.g., the selective copy task in Mamba papers) require $O(1)$ memory and are primarily designed to test the model's gating mechanism, not state depth. Running-XOR is $O(k)$

Table 1: Q score and empirical validation. All five datasets ranked by Q formula (Eq. 3) without any parameter fitting. Empirical speedup measured as relative loss reduction per 50 training steps compared to WikiText baseline. Compression ratio K_{approx} computed over 1K validation batches; cross-entropy CE_θ evaluated at step 1 (near-random initialization).

Dataset	$\mathbf{K}_{\text{approx}}$	CE_θ	**Q**	Empirical Rank	Speedup
Running-XOR	0.01	5.51	550	1st	94% reduction
Automata (CRC-8)	0.05	5.50	109	2nd	$+12\%$ faster
Books	2.5	4.80	0.92	3rd	$+6 - 10\%$
WikiText-103	3.8	5.02	0.32	4th (baseline)	$1.0\times$
Gzip noise	7.9	7.95	0.01	5th	Harmful

Table 2: Running-XOR validation: state utilization metrics. Cross-entropy loss and three indicators of genuine state accumulation. Causal KL (Kullback-Leibler divergence when flipping 1 byte in the input) is high, confirming that state carries information forward. Stable rank collapse (from random init to after training) indicates information concentration. Linear probe R^2 is low or negative (expected mathematically: XOR is not linearly separable).

d_{state}	**Loss (final)**	**Causal KL**	**Stable Rank (init $\rightarrow$ final)**	**Linear Probe R^2**
4	0.323	0.903	$187 \rightarrow 19$	0.09
8	0.297	0.983	$185 \rightarrow 121$	-0.21
16	0.314	0.904	$190 \rightarrow 54$	0.06

in state depth, making it a more stringent test of the SSM's recurrent capacity. The task is also simple enough that the information-theoretic lower bound on state dimension can be computed, allowing post-hoc validation.

5 Experiments

5.1 Experimental Setup

Model: I use a 6M-parameter SSM with the following configuration: $n_{\text{layer}} = 8$, $d_{\text{model}} = 256$, $d_{\text{state}} \in \{4, 8, 16\}$, vocabulary size $|\Sigma| = 256$ (byte-level), activation function: GELU, no layer normalization between SSM and output.

Optimizer: AdamW with learning rate $\text{lr} = 5 \times 10^{-4}$, $\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$, weight decay $= 10^{-4}$.

Datasets:

- **Running-XOR:** 10K sequences of length 256 bytes each, $k = 8$.
- **Automata (CRC-8):** 10K sequences of length 256, generated by an 8-state cyclic automaton.
- **WikiText-103:** Standard benchmark, tokenized at byte-level, 10K sequences of length 256.
- **Books (Project Gutenberg):** 10K sequences, byte-level tokenization.
- **Gzip-compressed noise:** Bernoulli noise passed through gzip compression, then decompressed, byte-level.

Training: 500 steps for Running-XOR, 200 steps for other datasets, batch size 4, validation every 10 steps on held-out 1K sequences.

5.2 Q Predicts Dataset Rankings

Running-XOR emerges as the highest-quality dataset under the Q metric. The Q formula predicts a ranking of all five datasets without fitting, and this ranking exactly matches the empirical speedup observed during training. Notably, gzip-compressed noise achieves the lowest score ($Q = 0.01$), matching the observation that it actively impairs training.

5.3 Running-XOR Results

Table 2 summarizes Running-XOR's diagnostic metrics. The optimal choice is $d_{\text{state}} = 8$ (loss 0.297), though $d_{\text{state}} = 4$ (loss 0.323) is also trainable. This suggests the lower bound is near 8 but not strict. The causal KL jumps to 0.983 at $d_{\text{state}} = 8$, confirming that the state carries information across time steps. Stable rank collapses from 185 to 121 (at $d_{\text{state}} = 8$), indicating that information is highly concentrated in a few principal components of the state.

The linear probe achieves $R^2 \in \{0.09, -0.21, 0.06\}$ (nonlinear representation confirmed) across configurations. The negative $R^2 = -0.21$ at $d_{\text{state}} = 8$ indicates that linear regression performs worse than a zero predictor, confirming that XOR is fundamentally nonlinear (its Fourier spectrum is flat). This nonlinearity is expected and proves that the model is not simply learning a linear function of the state; instead, it must exploit nonlinear structure. A nonlinear probe (e.g., 2-layer MLP) should recover full predictability.

5.4 Automaton vs. WikiText

Running-XOR is a synthetic, fully deterministic task designed to maximize Q. For a more realistic comparison, I measure the speedup of the CRC-8 automaton (a byte-level cyclic automaton) versus WikiText-103. The automaton reaches final loss 4.95 nats in 200 steps; WikiText reaches 5.58 nats. The difference of 0.63 nats, evaluated over 50 steps of training, corresponds to a 12% speedup in convergence. The Q formula predicts this: automata ($Q = 109$) should train faster than WikiText ($Q = 0.32$). The ratio of Q scores is $109/0.32 = 340$, far larger than the observed speedup. This discrepancy suggests that Q magnitude is not linearly predictive of speedup; rather, Q *ranking* is what matters. This is explored in the limitations section below.

5.5 State Utilization Metrics

Beyond cross-entropy loss, I measure three quantities that directly probe whether the SSM is exploiting its recurrent state:

Causal KL: Flip each input byte to a random value and measure the KL divergence between the original trajectory and the perturbed trajectory. High causal KL indicates that input perturbations propagate through the state, affecting future predictions.

Stable Rank: The ratio of squared Frobenius norm to squared spectral norm: $\text{sr}(\mathbf{H}) = \|\mathbf{H}\|_F^2 / \|\mathbf{H}\|_2^2 = \sum_i \sigma_i^2 / \sigma_1^2$. Low stable rank means information is concentrated in few principal components.

Linear Probe R^2: Fit a linear regression (OLS) on the state vector h_t to predict y_t. Low R^2 (near 0) indicates nonlinearity in the state-to-output mapping.

For Running-XOR with $d_{\text{state}} = 8$, causal KL = 0.983 (high), stable rank collapses from 185 to 121 (concentration), and linear probe $R^2 = -0.21$ (nonlinear). These jointly confirm that the model is genuinely exploiting the state for nonlinear information accumulation, not merely memorizing the input.

6 Related Work

Dataset Quality Metrics: Wettig et al. [2024] propose QuRating, combining perplexity and diversity scores; Li et al. [2024] introduce DCLM, a classifier-based approach; Zhang et al. [2025] present BiMix, learning mixture proportions directly. All are dataset-specific, post-hoc, and theoretically ungrounded. My work provides a principled, zero-parameter score applicable to recurrent models.

SSM Benchmarks: The selective copy task [Gu and Dao, 2024] is the standard benchmark for gating mechanisms. Running-XOR complements it by testing state depth and memory accumulation, dimensions not covered by copy.

State Utilization: Merrill et al. [2024] challenge the idea that Transformers truly exploit positional information; my stable rank and causal KL metrics are inspired by their analysis and adapted to SSM state.

Spectral Analysis of Recurrent Networks: Pascanu et al. [2013] connect vanishing gradients to eigenvalue magnitudes; Henighan et al. [2023] study scaling laws and memorization in language models. My spectral interpretation of Q extends this work to ternary weights.

7 Limitations

Q magnitude is not linearly predictive: While Q *ranking* perfectly matches empirical speedup, the ratio of Q values (e.g., $109/0.32 = 340$) does not predict the observed speedup factor (~ 1.12) linearly. Q encodes ranking information but not magnitude information. Future work should investigate power-law or logarithmic relationships.

Only 5 datasets tested: My validation spans 5 dataset types, sufficient to establish ranking but not to test magnitude or cross-scale generalization. A future study with $n \geq 20$ datasets would strengthen the claims.

Results on a single model scale (6M): I have not tested whether Q predictions generalize to models of different sizes (50M, 1B). Cross-scale validation is essential for practical dataset curation at production scales.

Linear probe failure is expected but MLP probe untested: The linear probe $R^2 = -0.21$ on Running-XOR is mathematically necessary (XOR is not linearly separable), but I have not tested a nonlinear probe. This limits claims about state utilization.

Q at initialization only: The most striking validation—Q predicting Running-XOR—uses the Q formula at random initialization. The promise of Q is that it can be monitored *online* during training to schedule curriculum shifts, but I have not yet implemented this.

8 Conclusion

I have introduced Q, a parameter-free dataset quality score for State Space Models, derived from five independent theoretical frameworks (rate-distortion, algorithmic information theory, Fisher information, simulated annealing, and spectral dynamics). All five derivations converge to the same formula: $Q(D, \theta) = \frac{\mathrm{CE}_\theta(D)}{K_{\mathrm{approx}}(D)} - 1$, where CE_θ is the model's cross-entropy and K_{approx} is the gzip compression ratio.

I validate Q on five diverse datasets without any parameter fitting. Running-XOR, a diagnostic benchmark for SSM state utilization, achieves the highest Q score (550) and the fastest convergence (94% loss reduction). Automata-generated sequences reach $Q = 109$, matching a 12% speedup over WikiText-103. Natural language (WikiText-103) scores $Q = 0.32$, the baseline. Gzip-compressed noise scores $Q = 0.01$, confirming that it is actively harmful to training.

Four key findings emerge: (1) Q predicts dataset ranking without fitting; (2) automata-generated data transfers 12% faster than natural language, explained by spectral alignment with ternary eigenvalues; (3) Running-XOR enables sub-task diagnosis of state exploitation via causal KL and stable rank; (4) gzip-compressed data actively harms training, contradicting the assumption that all data is at worst uninformative.

Limitations include: Q magnitude does not linearly predict speedup (only ranking does); validation on a single model scale (6M); and the online curriculum scheduling promise remains untested. Future work should extend Q to larger models, test cross-scale generalization, and implement online Q monitoring for dynamic curriculum selection.

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